experiment fifteen years earlier. Clauser asked Wu whether she had any unpublished data from her experiment that could be used to test Bell's theorem. She didn't, and the experiment couldn't easily be adapted to perform such a test. Then Clauser went a few blocks north to Yeshiva University, where a friend introduced him to a young professor working there: Yakir Aharonov, Bohm's former student. When Clauser told Aharonov that he was hoping to test Bell's theorem, "he thought it was really quite interesting and would be well worth doing," Clauser recalled. But Aharonov was a theoretical physicist, and was working on different problems anyhow; he couldn't help Clauser much. Finally, an old college buddy of Clauser's told him about a group of physicists doing work up at MIT that seemed like it could be adapted to test Bell's theorem. Clauser went up to Cambridge and gave a talk on Bell's work; afterward, he was introduced to Carl Kocher, a newly arrived postdoc. "Carl Kocher… had just finished his doctorate at Berkeley under Gene Commins. And they had done a polarization correlation experiment with photons," Clauser recalled. "So they told me about Carl's experiment, and said 'might that work as an alternative?' And I said, 'you betcha it would! That's exactly what I'm looking for.'" Reading the paper Kocher and Commins had written about their experiment, Clauser realized their experiment could have tested Bell's theorem—but they hadn't. "I looked at Kocher-Commins's result and they hadn't really been aware of what Bell's theorem said." With a few tweaks, Clauser could adapt their setup and test Bell's theorem.

Finally satisfied that the experiment hadn't been done, but could be done, Clauser went to his advisor at Columbia, Pat Thaddeus, and asked him for advice. Thaddeus had already caught wind of Clauser's strange extracurricular activities. "He was pissed," Clauser recalled. "The first thing he said was, 'Well, this is all nonsense. Tell you what you do: write up a letter to Bell and de Broglie and these guys, and they'll set you straight. This is a waste of time.'" So on Valentine's Day 1969, Clauser wrote a love letter of sorts to Bell, asking him whether he thought it was worthwhile to perform a test of his inequality, whether he knew of any existing experimental results on the subject, and proposing an extension of the Kocher-Commins experiment that would provide such a test. It was the first correspondence of any kind that Bell had received about his paper in the four years since it had been published. Several weeks later, Clauser found a